prepared for the invasion. The Chinese allowed India to believe that it could play a 'mediatory' role in peacefully resolving the Tibet issue. The Government of India was persuaded to encourage the Tibetan government to open negotiations with the new Chinese regime. Even as plans for the invasion were well underway, Premier Zhou Enlai told Panikkar in August 1950 that Beijing was anxious for a peaceful settlement. [8] Zhou also kept Panikkar, and Nehru, engaged on other international affairs with them; Zhou, for instance, would have long discussions with Panikkar on the situation in Formosa (Taiwan), Korea and China's case for membership of the United Nations.

The Chinese tactic was to distract India from thinking about a worst-case scenario on Tibet until it was too late for India to come to Tibet's assistance or to contemplate any coordinated action against China in the international arena. Detaching India from the Americans was their other priority while planning the invasion of Tibet. India's recognition of China was helpful, but suspicion about Indian intentions remained. Hence, from time to time, the state-run Chinese media would goad Nehru and India by questioning whether its foreign policy was really independent. Nehru would be labelled an 'imperialist lackey' who was helping in an Anglo-American plot to annex Tibet. By doing so, the Chinese hoped to play on India's anxiety about its international image as an independent power. It had the effect of compelling Nehru on more than one occasion to provide reassurances that India had neither material nor territorial ambitions in Tibet. This assurance was even provided in writing in the form of an Aide Memoire.

Thus, through a strategy of distraction and deception, China was able to ensure that until the invasion of Tibet began in October 1950, India never directly raised matters of its own interest or concern in Tibet with the Chinese side. Once the